

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN HAITI

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in Haiti turns on the most visible ecological catastrophe in the hemisphere — the near-total loss of the forests that once clothed these mountains, and the ruin that has followed — and it must be pursued, in a country whose state has largely collapsed and much of whose territory lies under armed-group control, very largely from outside and through the community: the vast Haitian diaspora, the international partners, and the local and agroforestry efforts that carry on even amid the crisis, always protecting anyone inside. Haiti is a mountainous Caribbean nation, the poorest in the western hemisphere, whose defining environmental question is the stripping of its steep hillsides of trees and then of soil. Haiti is a mountainous Caribbean nation on the island of Hispaniola, the poorest in the entire western hemisphere, whose defining environmental question is the near-total stripping of its steep hillsides of their trees and then of their soil, driven by the charcoal and fuelwood on which most families depend to cook, and the deadly cascade of erosion, flood, and landslide that has followed. That catastrophe — the forests lost to the charcoal economy, the soil washed from the bare slopes, and the disasters magnified by both — is the distinctive ground of environmental effort here, because in Haiti the reforestation of the land, the restoring of the soil, and the building of resilience are not one cause among many but the very difference between life and death in every storm. This guide will be honest from the outset about a crucial point of justice: the charcoal that drives the deforestation is not greed but survival, the fuel of families with no affordable alternative, so the answer can never be to punish the poor with bans, but must be to offer alternatives, livelihoods, and community-led restoration. This guide will be honest that the deforestation is all but complete; that the poverty and lack of alternatives driving the charcoal economy are profound; that the soil erosion is a vicious and worsening cycle; that reforestation has a long and fraught history of failure; that the disasters are recurrent and climate-amplified; and that the state has collapsed and the country is in profound crisis, so the work must run from outside and through the community, protecting anyone inside; but it will show that the levers here — the forests and the charcoal alternatives, the soil and the watersheds, the disasters and the resilience, the land and the water, and the diaspora and international channels — are real, and, as the reforestation efforts that continue even now show, genuinely usable.

The Haitian story teaches two things about defending the environment here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever pressed together. The second is distinctly Haitian, and it is what gives this guide its particular force. **Because the deforestation can be met by reforestation, agroforestry, and affordable cooking alternatives that offer livelihoods rather than bans, because the soil and the watersheds can be restored, because the disasters can be mitigated by trees in the right places, because the land and water can be defended, and because the vast diaspora and the international partners and the community efforts offer real channels a collapsed state cannot, the levers run through restoration and the community: the forests, the soil, the disasters, the land, and the channels.** That combination — the forests, the soil, the disasters, the land, and the channels — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because in a mountainous, deforested, crisis-stricken nation, the strongest ground is the restoration of the land through reforestation, agroforestry, and resilience, offering alternatives and livelihoods, and carried by the diaspora, the international, and the community.

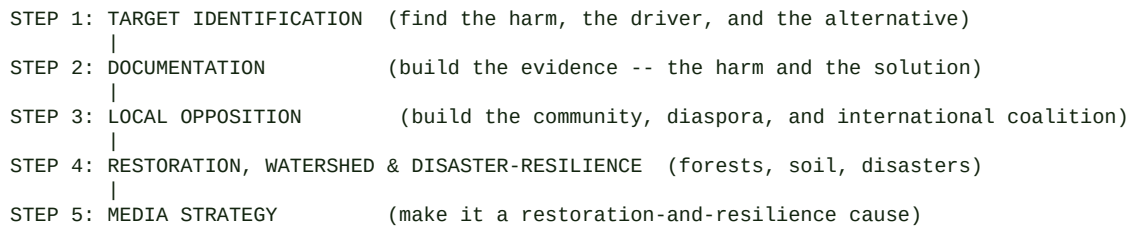
But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **The deforestation is near-total, the charcoal a matter of survival, the erosion a vicious cycle, reforestation historically fraught, and the state collapsed.** The deforestation is all but complete; the charcoal economy is driven by survival and the lack of alternatives, so justice forbids mere bans; the soil erosion is a worsening cycle; reforestation has failed often before; and the state has collapsed and the country is in crisis, so the work runs from outside and through the community, protecting anyone inside. This guide does not pretend the forests are not nearly gone, or that the charcoal can simply be banned, or that the state functions. What it shows is how, through the forests and alternatives, the soil and watersheds, the disasters and resilience, the land and water, and the channels, those who care — the diaspora, the international partners, and the communities and agroforestry workers where it is safe — can reforest and restore the land, defend the soil, and build resilience, from outside and through the community, and justly.

Most people who care about Haiti's environment do not know HOW to use the levers a collapsed, deforested, crisis-stricken nation offers. They see the barren moonscape hills, the topsoil gone, the rivers silted, the floods and landslides killing hundreds in every storm — and either despair of a ruined land and a fallen state, or imagine punitive bans that would starve the poor of fuel, and rarely grasp the levers that work: the community reforestation and agroforestry, the affordable cooking alternatives, the watershed restoration, the resilience, the diaspora and international support. The gap between the land restored and the land lost is here often a gap of method — the method of using the forests, the soil, the disasters, the land, and the channels together, justly and through the community.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Haitian reality as it is, which is a mountainous, deforested, crisis-stricken nation where restoration must come through the community, the diaspora, and the international, and justly. It is written for the person — in the vast Haitian diaspora, among the international partners, or in the communities and agroforestry efforts where it is safe — who sees the barren hills and the deadly floods and wants to know what can be done in a collapsed and deforested nation. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the forests and alternatives, the soil and watersheds, the disasters and resilience, the land and water, and the channels — with the honest qualifiers that the deforestation is near-total, the charcoal a matter of survival, the erosion a vicious cycle, reforestation historically fraught, and the state collapsed, so the work is external, community-based, diaspora-borne, and just, not punitive or domestic-confrontational. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used, because the Haitian case is particular and demands both justice and great care. It is for the person — in the vast Haitian diaspora, among the international partners, or in the communities and agroforestry efforts where it is safe — willing to do the patient, just, community-led work of restoring a ruined land, offering the poor livelihood rather than blame, and carrying it through the diaspora and the international where the state has fallen, rather than either despairing of a broken nation or imposing the punitive bans that would starve the desperate of fuel. That is not a lesser ambition but, for a collapsed and deforested state, the only responsible and just one, and it is also the only one that has ever worked, because the levers that genuinely deliver — community agroforestry that offers livelihood, affordable alternatives, watershed restoration, the diaspora, the international — all rest on relieving the poverty rather than punishing it, and never require endangering anyone. Anyone who approaches Haiti by blaming the charcoal-cutters may harm the very people they mean to help; anyone who works patiently, justly, and safely through community restoration and the diaspora can genuinely help bring a ruined hillside back to life. This guide is an honest map of that just, community-led, protective path.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, adapted to a collapsed, deforested, crisis-stricken nation:



These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of the harm and the solution feeds the reforestation, the watershed restoration, and the resilience at once; the community, diaspora, and international coalition organises; a tree-planting, a cooking-alternative, or a watershed effort is both a good in itself and a spur to the next. The effort that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still hard-won — chance of restoring the land and building resilience.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Haiti's — a collapsed, deforested, crisis-stricken nation — give a distinctive set:

- **The forests.** The **deforestation** can be met by reforestation, agroforestry, and affordable cooking alternatives that offer livelihoods, not bans — the distinctive lever.
- **The soil.** The **soil erosion** can be met by watershed restoration, soil conservation, and sustainable agriculture.
- **The disasters.** The **flood, landslide, and storm disasters** can be mitigated by trees in the right places and resilience.
- **The land.** The **land, the water, and the biodiversity** can be defended through community stewardship and the protection of remaining forest.
- **The channels.** The **vast diaspora, the international partners, and the community efforts** offer real channels a collapsed state cannot.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers restore the forests quickly, or that the charcoal can be banned, or that the state functions. The deforestation is **near-total**; the charcoal is **survival**; the erosion is a **vicious cycle**; reforestation is **historically fraught**; and the state is **collapsed**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it works through restoration, the community, and the diaspora, justly and protecting anyone inside — and shows how to use the real tools this situation offers — the forests, the soil, the disasters, the land, and the channels — to restore the land and build resilience, honestly acknowledging the near-total deforestation, the survival-driven charcoal, the vicious erosion, the fraught reforestation, and the collapsed state.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must see that the levers run largely through the outside and the community: the vast diaspora, the international partners and funders, the agroforestry and reforestation efforts, and the local communities where it is safe, because in a collapsed, crisis-stricken state where much of the territory lies under armed-group control, there is little functioning government to petition

and domestic confrontation is impossible and dangerous, so the restoration runs through the community and from outside. Before you spend a single week, map who actually can act, at which level, and where the leverage is real. And map where the forests, the soil, the disasters, the land, and the channels apply, because in Haiti a destructive harm is met not by a functioning state, but through community restoration, the diaspora, the international, and the affordable alternatives that make restoration just.

The Levels of Decision

A Haitian environmental effort runs through a collapsed state and a wide community and international system.

The remnant state and the environment ministry. The **remnant government and the environment ministry**, weak and crisis-bound, retain some plans and programmes, engaged where possible but unable to lead.

The communities and the agroforestry efforts. The **local communities, the farmers, and the agroforestry and reforestation efforts** hold the real capacity for restoration on the ground, where it is safe.

The diaspora and the international partners. The **vast Haitian diaspora, the international NGOs, funders, and agencies** carry much of the support, the funding, and the continuity a collapsed state cannot.

The scientists and technical experts. The **agronomists, foresters, and environmental scientists, many in the diaspora**, hold the case for what restoration works.

The disaster and resilience actors. The **disaster-risk, humanitarian, and resilience actors** hold the frameworks that link the forests and the floods.

The Journey of an Effort

A Haitian effort — reforesting a bare hillside, restoring a watershed, offering an alternative to charcoal, building resilience before the next storm — is carried through the **forests, the soil, the disasters, the land, and the channels**. **The forests and the soil are where the restoration begins, and the disasters, the land, and the channels are what carry it** — and using them together, through the community and the diaspora, is the distinctive Haitian approach. The distinctive levers are the **forests**, the **soil**, the **disasters**, the **land**, and the **channels**. Find out exactly what can be done where it is safe, and, crucially, **what hillside, watershed, soil, or community is at stake, what restoration and alternative would work and be just, and how the diaspora, the international, and the community can act**, because those are where an effort can genuinely take hold.

Follow the Harm, the Driver, and the Alternative

Behind the harm stand the poverty, the lack of alternatives, the collapsed state, and the hillsides, soil, watersheds, and communities at stake. Trace what is harmed, what drives it, and — importantly here — **what hillside, watershed, or community is degraded, what drives the degradation and what just alternative would relieve it, what restoration would work, and how the diaspora, the international, and the community can act**. Two questions unlock most Haitian efforts: **What is degraded, and what just restoration and alternative would relieve it?** and **Which lever — the forests, the soil, the disasters, the land, the channels — can carry it?** The community restoration, the just alternatives, and the diaspora and international support are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Haitian effort ultimately serves these: the documentation exists to establish the harm and the just, workable restoration that funders and communities will back; the community-diaspora-and-international coalition exists to carry that restoration where the state has fallen; and the external, just media exists to reach the diaspora and the

world with the story of a land restored by its own people. Keep the community restoration, the just alternatives, and the diaspora and international support at the centre of every effort and every story, and the work retains a clear spine that runs from a single bare hillside or a single charcoal-dependent family to the community agroforestry, the affordable alternatives, and the diaspora and international backing that can bring them back, grounding the whole in the just, community-led restoration through which a ruined and collapsed nation, hillside by hillside and family by family, can begin to heal its land and shield its people from the storms.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape an effort, because they are the levers. The **remnant state and environment ministry**; the **communities and agroforestry efforts**; the **diaspora and international partners**; the **scientists and technical experts**; and the **disaster and resilience actors**. In Haiti, the **forests, the soil, the disasters, the land, and the channels** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate front, and a bare hillside, an eroded watershed, a charcoal-dependent community, or a flood-prone valley can genuinely be met — through community restoration, just alternatives, the diaspora, and the international — though, honestly, the deforestation is near-total, the charcoal survival, the erosion a vicious cycle, reforestation fraught, and the state collapsed, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep working through restoration, the community, and the diaspora, justly and protecting anyone inside.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging the near-total deforestation, the collapsed state, and the survival-driven charcoal, even as community restoration, just alternatives, the diaspora, and the international give real, if hard-won, leverage. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how restoration efforts tend to go in collapsed, deforested, crisis-stricken states, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the effort can be **tied to a just alternative and a workable restoration**, whether the **community, the diaspora, and the international** can be engaged, and whether the work can be done **safely**. Where the restoration is community-designed and just and the channels used, the levers here are real, as the surviving reforestation efforts show; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the deforestation is near-total, the state collapsed, and the charcoal a matter of survival.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	15–25%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Forests / reforestation & alternatives	30–50%	years	low–moderate	Trees planted, alternatives offered, patches protected
Soil / watershed restoration	35–55%	years	low–moderate	The soil restored, the watershed stabilised
Disasters / resilience	35–55%	years	low	The floods and landslides mitigated
Land / water / biodiversity	30–50%	years	low	The remaining forest and water defended

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Community / agroforestry route	40–60%	years	low	The community restoration built where safe
Diaspora / international route	35–55%	months–years	low	The diaspora and partners engaged
All levers together	30–55%	years	moderate	Land restored, resilience built, from outside and community

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Haiti's real leverage is its communities and its diaspora: the **forests**, the **soil**, the **disasters**, the **land**, and the **channels**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the deforestation is **near-total**, the charcoal **survival**, the erosion a **vicious cycle**, reforestation **fraught**, and the state **collapsed** — but community restoration, just alternatives, the diaspora, and the international make the levers here genuinely usable, as the surviving efforts show.

*A note on cost and risk: most levers here — a community reforestation, an agroforestry effort, a cooking alternative, a watershed restoration — are carried by communities, the diaspora, and international partners, so the cost falls largely on them, and the effort is a good in itself. But the risk in a collapsed, gang-affected state is severe, so the safety of everyone involved must come first, gang-controlled areas must be avoided, and the work must run where it is safe and through those who can act without danger. The scarce resources are **the community and agroforestry capacity, the diaspora and international support, and the technical knowledge** — much of it reachable through the reforestation and agroforestry efforts, the diaspora networks, and the international NGOs and funders. This shapes where a Haitian effort should concentrate its energy. Because the decisive resources are community and agroforestry capacity, diaspora and international support, and the knowledge of what just restoration holds — rather than the state programmes that have collapsed or failed — an effort's most valuable investments are in building the community-led, livelihood-giving restoration, cultivating the diaspora and international relationships, and grounding the whole in the hard-won knowledge of what community-designed reforestation and alternatives actually work. A well-organised, well-connected, justly-framed effort that can mobilise a community to plant and tend agroforestry, offer affordable alternatives, restore a watershed, and draw the diaspora's and the international's support can achieve real, if patchwork, restoration in this ruined land, and can do so safely and community by community. The resources that matter most are thus largely a matter of community capacity, diaspora and international support, and the knowledge of just restoration — much of it reachable through the reforestation and agroforestry efforts, the diaspora networks, and the international NGOs and funders. And because the charcoal is survival, the just alternative — offering fuel and livelihood, not bans — is the most telling lever.*

Effectiveness Visualization

FORESTS + SOIL + DISASTERS + LAND + CHANNELS:

Community / agroforestry route: ■■■■■■■■■■ 40-60%
 Soil / watershed restoration: ■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%
 Disasters / resilience: ■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%
 Diaspora / international route: ■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%
 Forests / reforestation: ■■■■■■■■■■ 30-50%

NEAR-TOTAL DEFORESTATION / COLLAPSED STATE / SURVIVAL CHARCOAL -- harder ground:

Punitive bans on the poor: ■■ unjust, ineffective
 Restoration & just alternatives: ■■■■■■■■■■ the real path
 Land restored, resilience built: ■■■■■■■■■■ achievable in part
 The harm and solution documented: ■■■■■■■■■■ the reliable foundation

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Haiti are **the community and agroforestry route, the soil and watershed restoration, the disaster resilience, and the diaspora and international support** — used together, with the reforestation and just alternatives throughout. The community, soil, and disaster levers show the ceiling: community-designed restoration, watershed stabilisation, and resilience can achieve real, if partial, gains that save lives. The near-total deforestation and the collapsed state show the honest floor: the forests are nearly gone and the state cannot lead. Most Haitian efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real — able to restore the land and build resilience in part — but that punitive bans on the desperate are unjust and ineffective, and the surest result is that the restoration is done community by community, justly, through the diaspora, the international, and the affordable alternatives.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The community agroforestry and the just alternatives** — Haiti's distinctive levers; restoration that offers livelihood, not bans.
2. **The soil and watershed restoration** — the stabilising of the land and the stopping of the erosion.
3. **The disaster resilience** — the trees in the right places that save lives.
4. **The diaspora and international support** — the funding and continuity a collapsed state cannot give.
5. **The documented harm and solution** — the evidence that grounds it all.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **The forests are nearly gone** — the loss all but complete. **The charcoal is survival** — so justice forbids bans and demands alternatives. **Community-designed restoration works** — where it offers livelihood and is led locally. **Trees in the right places save lives** — the resilience is real. **But the state is collapsed and the crisis acute** — so the work is external, community-based, and safe. The through-line: **document the harm and the just solution; reforest and offer affordable alternatives that give livelihood, not bans; restore the soil and the watersheds; build disaster resilience with trees in the right places; defend the remaining forest, land, and water; use the community, the diaspora, and the international; and protect everyone involved — because an effort that does can genuinely restore the land and build resilience, community by community, while being honest that the deforestation is near-total, the state collapsed, and the charcoal a matter of survival.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact harm and the just solution — and the leverage, which here runs through community restoration, affordable alternatives, and the diaspora and international. Vague concern goes nowhere, and punitive bans are unjust and self-defeating; an effort aimed at "this degraded hillside or watershed or community, which a just, community-designed restoration and affordable alternative can relieve, carried by the diaspora, the international, or the community" is a real, workable effort. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. What is degraded? This is the first question here. What **hillside, watershed, soil, forest, or community** is degraded — the bare slopes, the eroded watershed, the silted river, the flood-prone valley, the charcoal-dependent community.

2. What just restoration and alternative would relieve it? What **community-designed reforestation, agroforestry, watershed restoration, or affordable cooking alternative** would relieve it — justly, offering livelihood, not bans.

3. Is it the forests, the soil, or the disasters? Whether the matter is one of the **forests and charcoal**, the **soil and watersheds**, or the **disasters and resilience** — for each has its levers.

4. What driver and livelihood apply? What **poverty, energy need, or land pressure** drives the degradation, and **what livelihood must the solution provide**, for the answer must be just.

5. How can the diaspora, international, and community act, safely? How the **diaspora, the international partners, and the communities and agroforestry efforts** can act — where it is safe, protecting everyone.

A Worked Example

Suppose a mountain community strips its last trees for charcoal to survive, the bare slopes erode with every rain, the silt chokes the river below, and the next storm threatens deadly floods and landslides — yet the families have no other fuel or income.

Working the five questions: **what is degraded? What just restoration and alternative would relieve it? Is it the forests, the soil, or the disasters? What driver and livelihood apply?** And how can the diaspora, international, and community act, safely? The driver is the survival charcoal and the erosion, with community agroforestry, affordable alternatives, and watershed restoration as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the hills are ruined and nothing can be done" to a real, just effort: work with the community to plant agroforestry that supplies fuelwood, fruit, and income while stabilising the slopes; offer affordable cooking alternatives so the last trees need not be cut; restore the watershed; and draw on the diaspora and international support — all where it is safe, and offering livelihood rather than bans. That is a workable effort suited to Haiti — one that restores the land through community agroforestry, just alternatives, and the diaspora, where it is safe. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit an effort in a collapsed, deforested, desperately poor nation: they turn what might seem an unanswerable catastrophe — a ruined land, a fallen state, a people with no fuel but the last trees — into a set of specific, answerable questions, each attached to a lever that rests on community restoration, just alternatives, and the diaspora, rather than on a functioning state that does not exist or a punitive ban that would be cruel. The harm becomes a documentable bare slope, eroded watershed, or flood risk. The just solution becomes a community-designed agroforestry, an affordable alternative, or a watershed restoration that offers livelihood. The category becomes the forests, the soil, or the disasters, each with its levers. The driver becomes the poverty and energy need the solution must relieve. And the channels become the community, the diaspora, and the international, where it is safe. That translation — from an unanswerable catastrophe into a set of specific, just, community-led actions — is the first and most important thing a Haitian effort does, because it moves the work from the despair of a ruined land onto the firm ground of community restoration, where, tree by tree and justly, a hillside can genuinely be brought back.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, distinctively, the decisive evidence is the harm and the just, workable solution, which is what draws the diaspora, the international funders, and the community to a restoration that will hold. A funder, an NGO, a community, and the diaspora all move on

evidence — and for Haiti, a clear record of the degradation and the community-designed, just restoration that would relieve it is precisely what an external and community effort turns into a real result, so build it well, and safely. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Harm, the Driver, and the Just Solution

Get the facts the effort turns on. Identify the **harm** — the deforestation, the erosion, the silting, the flood risk — and, decisively here, **the driver and the just solution**: the survival charcoal and poverty that drive it, and the community-designed reforestation, agroforestry, alternative, or restoration that would relieve it while offering livelihood. Establish exactly **what is degraded, what drives it, and what just restoration would relieve it**, because the harm-and-its-just-solution is the effort's foundation.

Layer 2: The Harm, the Science, and the Restoration

Document the harm with the science. Establish the **environmental harm** — the forest loss, the soil erosion, the watershed degradation, the flood and landslide risk — and the **restoration that works** — drawing on **the agronomic and forestry science, the watershed and disaster data, the agroforestry evidence, and the community's own knowledge**. This harm-and-restoration evidence turns the concern into a documented case that a just, community-designed restoration would relieve — and that funders and communities will back.

Layer 3: The Case, the Livelihood, the Channel, and the Safety

Finally, document the case and the path. Does the **restoration** offer a just livelihood as well as an environmental gain? What **livelihood and alternative** must it provide? Which **community, diaspora, international, or agroforestry channel** will carry it? And how will everyone be **kept safe** in a collapsed, gang-affected state? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case a just, community restoration can be built on. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented harm, a just and workable restoration, a livelihood, a channel, and a safe path are exactly what let a Haitian effort restore the land and build resilience. Build it well, and the forests, the soil, the disasters, the land, and the channels become the effort's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: because Haiti's environmental catastrophe is among the most studied and documented in the world — its deforestation charted for decades, its erosion mapped, its disasters recorded in tragic detail, and its restoration methods tested and assessed by agronomists, foresters, and development researchers — a great deal of the necessary evidence already exists, much of it produced by the diaspora's own scholars and by international partners, and is genuinely obtainable from outside. The forest-cover figures, the erosion assessments, the disaster records, the agroforestry and watershed studies, and the hard-won lessons of what reforestation has failed and what has worked are, in large part, matters of public and scientific record. This means an effort can often build its case substantially from that existing record, rather than gathering dangerous new evidence inside a crisis-stricken land, and can draw especially on the accumulated knowledge of which community-led, livelihood-giving approaches actually hold. Building this layer well therefore means marshalling that rich existing record — the science, the disaster history, the lessons of past restoration — and joining it to the communities' own knowledge of their hills, so that the case rests on a solid foundation of what just, community-designed restoration genuinely achieves.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists — and here much of it lives in the agronomic and forestry science, the watershed and disaster data, the agroforestry evidence, and the deep knowledge of the

communities and the diaspora. Here is where the material tends to live in a Haitian effort, and how to get it — with the **harm**, the **driver**, the **just restoration**, and the **livelihood** at the center, and the safety of everyone always first. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Harm and Driver Record

Start with the harm and the driver. **The forest, soil, and watershed data, the disaster records, and the community knowledge** establish the harm and its causes; the distinctive strengths here are the **stark, well-documented record of the deforestation and its consequences** and the **understanding that the driver is survival, not greed**. Establish the **harm, its scale, and the driver** — the deforestation, the erosion, the charcoal dependence, the poverty. Establish exactly **what is degraded and what drives it**, because a harm understood together with its just driver points to a just solution.

The Harm, Science, and Restoration Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **harm evidence** — the forest loss, the soil erosion, the watershed degradation, the disaster risk — and the **restoration that works** — drawing on **the agronomic and forestry science, the agroforestry and watershed evidence, the disaster-risk data, and the community's knowledge of what has worked and failed**. This harm-and-restoration evidence, grounded in what community-designed, just restoration actually achieves, is what turns the concern into a workable, fundable effort.

The Alternative, Livelihood, and Resilience Record

Document the levers of the solution. Gather the record of **the affordable cooking alternatives — improved stoves, briquettes from agricultural waste, other fuels — and the livelihoods they and agroforestry can provide; the watershed and soil-conservation methods; and the disaster-resilience frameworks that link the forests and the floods**. A community and its allies that understand the just alternatives, the restoration methods, and the resilience hold the levers that make restoration both effective and just.

The Community, Diaspora, and International Record

Document the wider levers. Gather the record of the **communities, farmers, and agroforestry efforts that carry restoration on the ground; the vast Haitian diaspora and its networks; and the international NGOs, funders, and technical partners**. A community and its allies joined to the diaspora and the international hold levers that carry restoration where a collapsed state cannot, and that continue even amid the crisis.

The People, the Livelihood, and the Safety

Finally, and most importantly, map the human terrain and the safety it requires. Who is affected — the **mountain and rural communities, the charcoal-dependent families, the flood-threatened valleys, and the future generations** — and who can act safely: the **communities and agroforestry efforts where it is safe, the diaspora, and the international partners**. And how does the effort **offer livelihood, not bans, and keep everyone safe** in a collapsed, gang-affected state? A Haitian effort is advanced through the forests, the soil, the disasters, the land, and the channels — so map that coalition deliberately, offer livelihood and justice, avoid the areas of danger, and let the safety of everyone govern every step.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here this step must be understood in a way unlike a functioning society, because Haiti's state has collapsed, much of the territory lies under armed-group control, and adversarial organising is impossible and dangerous, so the "opposition" that works is not confrontation but the constructive building of community restoration, carried where it is safe and joined to the diaspora and the international, with everyone protected. The task is to build a coalition — of communities, agroforestry efforts, the diaspora, and international partners — that restores the land and builds resilience, justly and safely.

Why the Community-Diaspora-and-International Coalition Is Decisive

In Haiti, the coalition that can act joins the communities and agroforestry efforts to the diaspora and the international, because a collapsed state cannot lead, but the communities can restore where it is safe, and the diaspora and the international can fund and sustain them. That coalition supplies what a restoration effort runs on: the communities and farmers who plant and tend the trees, the agroforestry efforts that make restoration pay, the vast diaspora that funds and connects, and the international partners who bring the science and the support. When the communities, the diaspora, and the international act together, safely, they become a genuine force. **A coalition that is community-based, diaspora-borne, and internationally supported here is not a weaker substitute for a functioning state; it is the only safe and effective form restoration can take in a collapsed one — the real foundation of a Haitian effort, restoring the land community by community, justly, while everyone is protected.** This is worth dwelling on, because the particular conditions of Haiti make this community, diaspora, and international approach not a fallback but the only responsible and effective one. In a functioning country, environmental restoration can lean on the state — on forestry departments, on enforcement, on national programmes; in Haiti, the state has collapsed, national reforestation schemes have a long history of failure, and much of the territory is dangerous, so that avenue is both broken and, in many places, perilous. But Haiti possesses a different and genuine strength that few collapsed states can match: one of the largest and most engaged diasporas in the world, deeply tied to its home communities and willing to fund and sustain them; a tradition of community and agroforestry effort that continues even amid the crisis, as the reforestation projects surging ahead in the last forests attest; and a wealth of international goodwill and technical partnership. The task, therefore, is to build the coalition that joins these: the communities who plant and tend the trees where it is safe, the diaspora who fund and connect, and the international partners who bring the science and the support. This is not a weaker path but, for a collapsed state, the only safe and effective one, for it restores the land precisely where the fallen state cannot, community by community, while every person involved is protected and the desperate are offered livelihood rather than blame.

Finding the Coalition

Begin not with confrontation, which is impossible and dangerous, but with those who can act safely — the **communities and farmers, the agroforestry and reforestation efforts, the diaspora, and the international partners** — and protect everyone, avoiding the areas of danger. Widen to the wider diaspora and the international community that care for Haiti. Name the shared stake — **our hills, our soil, our water, and the safety of our families in every storm** — because in Haiti the restoration of the land and the saving of lives are the same. Frame the effort around just, community-led restoration that offers livelihood, carried where it is safe. There is real power, and real justice, in framing the cause this way, because it locates the entire effort on the one ground where a ruined and collapsed nation's restoration is genuinely possible, and where the poor are made partners rather than culprits. A cause framed as opposition to the charcoal-cutters, or as bans on the desperate, would be unjust, self-defeating, and cruel, for it would punish survival; a cause framed as community-led restoration that offers livelihood — agroforestry that yields fuelwood, fruit, and income, alternatives that spare the last trees, resilience that protects families — makes the very people who

cut the trees into the people who restore the hills, because it gives them a better way to live. This framing is not only the more effective one; it is also the more just, because in Haiti the deforestation is not a crime of greed but a symptom of poverty, so the answer must relieve the poverty, not punish it. An effort that names this frame precisely — just, community-led restoration that offers livelihood — stands on the only ground that a ruined, collapsed, desperately poor nation genuinely affords, and the only one worthy of its people.

Coalition-Building, Through Community, Diaspora, and International

A coalition allied is stronger than any single actor, and for Haiti it is built through the community, the diaspora, and the international. Reach to the **communities and farmers**; the **agroforestry and reforestation efforts**; the **vast diaspora and its networks**; the **international NGOs, funders, and technical partners**; and the **remnant environmental institutions** where they function. Frame the coalition around the forests, the soil, the disasters, and the land. Build breadth through the community and the diaspora, offering livelihood and keeping everyone safe — for the coalition's strength is the union of community restoration, diaspora support, and international backing where the state has failed.

Sustaining the Effort

Haitian efforts are sustained through the community, the diaspora, and the international. Keep the coalition **connected, funded, and safe**, and the restoration **just and livelihood-giving**; mark real steps — a hillside reforested, a watershed restored, an alternative fuel adopted, a community made more resilient, a forest patch protected. And keep the effort grounded in the land, the livelihood, and the safety of the people, which endure and unite. The effort that lasts is the one that joins the community to the diaspora and the international, offers livelihood and justice, keeps everyone safe, and restores the land patch by patch even amid the crisis.

STEP 4: RESTORATION, WATERSHED & DISASTER-RESILIENCE CHALLENGES — THE FORESTS, THE SOIL, AND THE DISASTERS

This is where a Haitian effort is realistically advanced — not through a functioning state, which does not exist, but through the **community reforestation and just alternatives, the restoration of the soil and watersheds, and the building of disaster resilience** — carried from outside and through the community, justly and safely. Here the forests, soil, and disaster levers come together, because in Haiti a harm can be met through community restoration, just alternatives, the diaspora, and the international, where it is safe.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but slow, partial, community-scale, and hard-won, and the forests cannot be swiftly restored**. The reforestation is **real but slow and historically fraught, and must offer alternatives**; the soil restoration is **achievable watershed by watershed, though the erosion is severe**; the disaster resilience is **genuine, for trees in the right places save lives**; and the state cannot **lead**. What these levers realistically achieve is **hillsides reforested, watersheds restored, alternatives offered, and resilience built, community by community** — real, if partial, outcomes from outside and through the community, not the swift restoration of a lost forest cover. Enter this front clear-eyed and just: the forests, the soil, and the disasters are Haiti's distinctive levers, strongest when the **restoration is community-designed, just, and livelihood-giving** — but slow, partial, and safe.

The Forests and the Just Alternatives

The first front is the forests and the alternatives. The **near-total deforestation, driven by the charcoal and fuelwood on which families depend**, can be met through **community reforestation and agroforestry that supply fuelwood, fruit, and income while stabilising the slopes, and through affordable cooking alternatives — improved stoves, briquettes from agricultural waste, and other fuels — that relieve the pressure on the last trees**, and through the protection of the remaining forest patches, which is more cost-effective than replanting. Use the forests and the just alternatives, because the charcoal is survival and cannot justly be banned, so the answer is restoration that offers livelihood and alternatives that offer fuel — a reforestation that feeds families as it clothes the hills. It is worth being clear about both the power and the limits of this forests-and-alternatives front, honestly, for it is the most distinctive lever a Haitian effort holds, and the one that most demands justice. Its power lies in a simple truth: because the deforestation is driven by the need for fuel and income, a restoration that supplies both — agroforestry that yields fuelwood, fruit, and cash while it holds the soil, and affordable alternatives that spare the last trees — attacks the problem at its root and enlists the very people who cut the trees as the ones who plant them. Its limits are equally real and must be stated plainly: reforestation is slow, and Haiti's history is littered with top-down tree-planting schemes that failed because they ignored the people's needs; the alternatives require investment and supply chains that a collapsed state cannot provide; and the pressure of poverty is relentless. Understanding both means using this front for what it does best — community-designed restoration that offers livelihood and alternatives that offer fuel — while heeding the hard lesson of the failures, that a restoration which does not feed the family will not hold the hill, and that only the just approach, which relieves the poverty rather than punishing it, has ever taken root in Haiti.

The Soil and the Watersheds

The second front is the soil. The **catastrophic erosion of the bare hillsides, the silting of the rivers, and the loss of the fertile land** can be met through **watershed restoration, soil conservation — terraces, contour planting, conservation agriculture — and the agroforestry that stabilises the slopes**, coordinated where possible at the scale of whole river basins, upstream and downstream. Use the soil and the watersheds, because the erosion is the vicious heart of Haiti's environmental ruin — stripping the farmland, silting the rivers, and worsening the floods — and restoring the soil and the watersheds restores the land's productivity, its water, and its safety together.

The Disasters and the Resilience

The third front is the disasters. The **deadly floods, landslides, and storm and earthquake disasters, magnified by the barren slopes**, can be mitigated through **reforestation and watershed restoration in the right places, disaster-risk reduction, and resilience** — for trees on the slopes and along the rivers absorb the rain, anchor the soil, and buffer the communities below. Use the disasters and the resilience, because in Haiti the environmental restoration is, quite literally, disaster mitigation and the saving of lives — the trees in the right places that turn a killing flood into a survivable storm. Pursued together — the forests, the soil, and the disasters — these fronts are how a Haitian effort restores the land and builds resilience, through community restoration, just alternatives, the diaspora, and the international, justly and where it is safe. It is worth understanding why these fronts reinforce one another so well in Haiti's particular situation, for they are bound together by the same trees. The forests-and-alternatives front replaces the cutting with agroforestry and affordable fuel, relieving the pressure at its source. The soil-and-watershed front stabilises the slopes and rivers that the lost trees once held. And the disaster-resilience front turns the same reforestation into a shield against the floods and landslides. Each covers the others' reach: the forests at the level of the driver and the livelihood, the soil at the level of the eroding land, and the disasters at the level of the storms that kill. And each strengthens the others, for the agroforestry that offers livelihood is the same

that stabilises the soil and buffers the floods, the watershed restored is the same that feeds the farmland and slows the torrent, and the tree planted for fuel is the tree that holds the hillside and saves the village below. An effort that grasps this mutual reinforcement, and pursues each front together through the community and the diaspora, makes the fullest use of the several restoration levers that a ruined but not hopeless land provides — for in Haiti a single well-placed tree can be fuel, soil, and safety at once.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each partner in the language that moves them. The same file of harm and just restoration becomes different arguments for the communities, the diaspora, the international funders, the technical partners, and the remnant institutions. Translate deliberately, and always justly and safely.

For the Communities

The communities respond to **the livelihood, the safety, and the land**. Frame the restoration as a good for them: here is the agroforestry that gives fuelwood, fruit, and income, the alternative that spares your last trees, the trees that will protect your homes in the next storm. Give them the restoration that pays and protects, designed with them. Make it concrete: *here is the reforestation that feeds your family as it holds the soil, and the fuel that need not cost the last tree*. This is the argument that makes restoration take root, because it offers livelihood, not loss.

For the Diaspora

The diaspora responds to **the homeland, the community, and the tangible good**. Frame the restoration as a way to help the home communities directly: here is the hillside restored, the watershed stabilised, the community made safer, the tangible good your support achieves. Give them the concrete, community-led effort, and enlist their funding, connection, and voice. The vast diaspora, engaged around a tangible restoration, is Haiti's greatest external resource.

For the International Funders and Technical Partners

The funders and partners respond to **the workable solution, the science, and the resilience**. Frame the restoration as a proven, fundable, resilience-building effort: here is the community-designed agroforestry, the watershed restoration, the disaster resilience, the science that shows it works. Give them the workable case and the community foundation, and press for the funding and technical support. A funder or partner with a workable, community-led, resilience-building effort can sustain what a collapsed state cannot.

For the Remnant Institutions and the World

The remnant institutions and the world respond to **the restoration and the crisis**. Translate the file into the story of a ruined land restored community by community: here is the deforestation, the erosion, the deadly floods, and the restoration that saves lives. Frame it as the restoration of a land and the saving of its people. Keep it accurate and just; and protect everyone involved. And speak to the world's concern for a nation in crisis.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, offer livelihood not bans, and keep everyone safe. Your credibility rests on the real harm and the real, just, workable restoration — community-designed, livelihood-giving, and safe; and the justice of offering alternatives rather than punishing the poor is both right and effective. State the

harm precisely, tie it to the forests, the soil, or the disasters, and press through the community, the diaspora, and the international. An effort that is precise, just, community-designed, and safe is far more effective than one that overreaches, blames the poor, or endangers anyone in a collapsed and dangerous state.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into support — and here, for a nation in profound crisis, the domestic space is broken and dangerous, so the "media" that works is the international coverage and the diaspora's voice that reach the world's and the diaspora's concern for Haiti, always justly and safely. The story — a ruined land and its people restoring the hills, saving lives in every storm — resonates internationally and in the diaspora, if told with justice and care.

Why Media Matters

The diaspora, the international funders, the technical partners, and the world behave differently when the harm and the just restoration are visible. Media does three things here: it **connects the diaspora and the world to the community restoration**, it **raises the support** for a nation in crisis, and it **reaches the funders, the partners, and the diaspora**. But the domestic space is broken and dangerous, so the media effort runs through **international coverage, the diaspora's voice, and careful, just documentation**, protecting everyone involved, and always framing the poor as those to be helped, not blamed.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the restoration and the justice. The strongest frame is concrete, just, and hopeful: *a people restoring their ruined hills — planting trees that feed families and hold the soil, offering fuel that spares the last forest, and building the resilience that saves lives in every storm*. Put the community restoration and the justice first, because the story of a land restored by its own people, justly and against the odds, is powerful and true, and the story that blames the desperate for their fuel is neither. Keep it scrupulously accurate and just; and protect everyone involved. The Haitian story is powerful because the ruin is real, the restoration is real, and the justice of offering livelihood rather than blame is real.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, all external and safe. **International coverage and the diaspora's networks** for the world and the diaspora; **the funder and NGO channels** for the support; **the technical and scientific channels** for the restoration evidence; and **the community networks** where safe. Because the domestic space is broken and dangerous, the external and diaspora channels are the ones that carry the story, and the safety of everyone comes first — the ruin, the restoration, and the justice are the story's power.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, just, external, and safe — the aim is the restoration of the land and the saving of lives, framed around the forests, the soil, and the disasters, and never blaming the poor or endangering anyone. Frame the story around the restoration and the resilience, and handle the crisis, the gangs, the politics, and the foreign interventions factually and from the safety of outside, keeping the focus on the environment and the just restoration. Handle the sensitive matters through the careful international record, never through anything that could endanger a person inside. And sustain the story across the slow work of restoration. Above all, let the ruined land, the community restoration, and the justice of livelihood carry the story, because that is where a Haitian effort is strongest and safest.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real harm and the just restoration, keep it factual and just, offer livelihood not bans, and keep everyone safe. Here the community, the diaspora, and the international win. These are addressed to partners and supporters, not to anyone endangered.

8A: To an International Funder or NGO

Subject: Community reforestation and resilience in [area]

To [funder / NGO],

We write regarding a community-led effort to restore [the degraded hillside / watershed] in [area], through agroforestry that offers fuelwood, fruit, and income while stabilising the slopes and reducing flood and landslide risk. We respectfully seek your funding and technical support for this just, community-designed restoration. We attach the plan and evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name / organisation, contact]

8B: The Forests / Alternatives Case

Subject: Reforestation and affordable cooking alternatives in [area]

To [partner / funder],

The deforestation in [area], driven by families' need for charcoal, can be relieved not by bans but by agroforestry that supplies fuelwood and income and by affordable alternatives — improved stoves, briquettes, other fuels. We respectfully seek support for this just approach. We attach the plan.

Respectfully,

[Name, community effort, contact]

8C: The Soil / Watershed Case

Subject: Watershed restoration and soil conservation in [area]

To [technical / funding partner],

The erosion in [area] is silting the rivers and ruining the farmland. We respectfully seek support for watershed restoration and soil conservation — terraces, contour planting, conservation agriculture, and agroforestry — at the scale of the river basin. We attach the assessment.

Respectfully,

[Name, community effort, contact]

8D: The Disaster-Resilience Case

Subject: Reforestation for disaster resilience in [area]

To [disaster / resilience partner],

The bare slopes of [area] turn every storm into deadly floods and landslides. We respectfully seek support for reforestation and watershed restoration in the right places to buffer the communities and save lives. We attach the risk analysis.

Respectfully,

[Name, community effort, contact]

8E: The Land / Forest-Patch Case

Subject: Protecting the remaining forest at [location]

To [conservation partner],

The remaining forest at [location] — among Haiti's last — protects soil, water, and life, and safeguarding it is more cost-effective than replanting. We respectfully seek support for its protection, paired with alternatives for the families who depend on it. We attach the evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name, community effort, contact]

8F: To the Diaspora

Subject: Restoring our hills — how the diaspora can help

Dear friends,

Our home communities are restoring their ruined hills — planting trees that feed families and hold the soil, offering fuel that spares the last forest, building resilience against the storms. From abroad, we can fund, connect, and sustain this work where those at home cannot do it alone. Please join us in restoring the land of our home, safely and justly.

With respect,

[Name / organisation]

8G: Media / Documentation Pitch

Subject: A ruined land, restored by its own people

Dear [journalist / editor],

In Haiti, amid profound crisis, communities are restoring their deforested hills — planting agroforestry that feeds families and holds the soil, offering alternatives to charcoal, and building the resilience that saves lives in every storm. There is a powerful, just, hopeful story here, and we can provide the evidence and the community's voices, safely.

Sincerely,

[Name, contact]

8H: To Community Partners (where safe)

Subject: Restoring our land, feeding our families

Dear neighbours,

Our hills are bare, our soil is washing away, and every storm brings danger. But together, where it is safe, by planting the trees that give us fuelwood, fruit, and income while they hold our soil, and by finding fuel that spares our last trees, we can restore our land and protect our families. Please join us, safely and with care for one another: share what you know, and let us restore our hills together.

With respect,

[Name, community]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes an effort is acute — a hurricane season approaching bare slopes, a last forest patch being cut, a watershed failing, a community out of fuel — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and most safely here, which means the community agroforestry, the just alternatives, and the diaspora and international support, protecting everyone.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials: **what is degraded, and what just restoration and alternative would relieve it.** Identify the immediate harm — **a bare slope before a storm, a forest patch being cut, a failing watershed, a fuel shortage** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **community, the agroforestry efforts, and the diaspora and international partners** at once, because in Haiti the community restoration, the just alternatives, and the diaspora and international support are the fastest routes to real leverage — and keep everyone safe from the start, avoiding the areas of danger.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The community agroforestry** can begin quickly where it is safe. **The affordable alternative** — a stove, a briquette source — can relieve the pressure fast. **The diaspora** can mobilise funding quickly around a concrete effort. **The forest-patch protection** can be organised fast, more cheaply than replanting. These outpace the slower work of the deep watershed restoration and the wide reforestation — which must follow — because the community, the alternatives, and the diaspora can be brought to bear immediately. Above all, if a storm threatens or a last patch is being cut, protect the patch and the community fast, because a standing forest saves lives and is cheaper to keep than to replace.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but for Haiti you can reach the community, the diaspora, and the international fast, and safely. Reach immediately to the **community and agroforestry efforts, the diaspora, and the international partners**, protecting everyone and avoiding danger. A coalition beginning the community restoration, offering the just alternative, and drawing the diaspora is the most a rapid Haitian effort can do. Speed favours the prepared: know the harm, the just solution, and the safe channels before the crisis breaks, and offer livelihood, not bans.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the field is tilted about as far as any in this series, by a state that has collapsed and cannot govern or lead, by armed groups that control much of the territory, by an extreme poverty that leaves families no fuel but the last trees, by a reforestation history littered with failed top-down schemes, and by a crisis that consumes everything. Name it plainly, because pretending the state functions, or that the charcoal

can be banned, or that restoration is easy, would each be false — but the community, the diaspora, the international, and the justice of offering livelihood make even this deeply tilted field one where careful, community-led, just restoration can take root.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **The state has collapsed** — no functioning government to lead. **Armed groups control much territory** — vast areas dangerous. **The poverty is extreme** — the charcoal a survival with no alternative. **Reforestation has often failed** — top-down schemes that ignored the people. And **the crisis consumes all**. But **the community, the diaspora, the international, and the justice of livelihood** are real levers. This is a tilt about as steep as any, worked through community restoration, just alternatives, the diaspora, and the international, protecting everyone, not through a functioning state that does not exist.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is this tilted, use the community, diaspora, and just levers. Lean on the **communities**, who can restore where it is safe; the **diaspora**, which funds and sustains; the **international partners**, who bring science and support; the **agroforestry that offers livelihood**, which makes restoration take root; and above all the **justice of offering alternatives rather than bans**, which turns the poor from the blamed into the restorers. Meet the collapsed state not with confrontation but with community restoration that continues even amid the crisis, as the surviving reforestation efforts show. And build the community, diaspora, and international coalition over time, because these accumulate into real, if patchwork, restoration. A field tilted this far is worked through community, diaspora, and just restoration, protecting everyone, not through a state that has fallen.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may achieve little against the vast ruin — the hills may stay bare, the soil may keep washing away, the storms may keep killing — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the tilt is among the steepest and the deforestation near-total. But even here the work is rarely wholly wasted: the **hillside was reforested, the watershed restored, the alternative offered, the community made safer, the patch protected** — and every hillside restored, every alternative offered, every community made more resilient saves real lives in the next storm and builds the patchwork of restoration that a ruined land is rebuilt from. Press, safely and justly, for the land's restoration; even amid the crisis, the trees you plant and the resilience you build will hold soil and save lives, as the reforestation efforts that surge ahead even now attest — for a restored hillside is a real and lasting good, whatever the wider ruin.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In Haiti, alongside the honest tilt of a collapsed state, there is a real and painful dimension of capture, because the country's history is marked by the misdirection of aid, reconstruction, and public funds — the resources meant for the people too often lost to the connected before they reached the communities — and because restoration itself can be captured by top-down schemes that enrich contractors while the hills stay bare. The harm here is partly the capture of the aid, the resources, and even the restoration by those who profit from a broken system. The response runs through transparent, community-direct, and accountable support.

Telling Capture from the Ordinary Tilt

Here the capture is bound up with a collapsed state and a long history of misdirected aid, and its marks are specific: **the aid and reconstruction funds lost before they reach the communities, the top-down restoration schemes that enrich contractors and fail the hills, the resources serving the connected over the people, and the communities who do the work seeing little of the support.** The task is to document it and route around it through the transparency, the community-direct support, and the accountable channels, relying on the international monitoring, the funding records, and the community's own account. And note that the antidote to captured aid is community-led, transparent, direct restoration — support that reaches the hands that plant the trees.

Responding to Capture — Through Community-Direct and Transparent Support

Where the capture is real, the response runs through the community-direct and transparent channels. Use the **community-led, direct restoration** that puts support in the hands that do the work, bypassing the captured intermediaries. Use the **transparency and accountability** of reputable funders and monitors to track where support goes. Use the **diaspora's direct connection** to the home communities. And use the **documentation** of what reaches the ground and what does not. Document rigorously, route support directly to the communities, and keep everyone safe, because in Haiti the surest answer to captured aid is restoration led by and funded directly to the communities themselves. Route the effort through the community-direct, the transparent, and the accountable — never through the captured top-down schemes that have failed the hills before.

A Note on Safety and Protection

This note matters greatly here, and governs everything. Haiti is a nation in profound crisis, its state collapsed and much of its territory under armed-group control, so this work must protect everyone involved absolutely and run only where it is safe. Work through the **community, diaspora, and international channels**, and only in areas that are safe; never expose or endanger anyone, and treat the safety of all involved as the first and overriding consideration; avoid the areas under armed-group control; frame the work as community restoration and the saving of lives, offering livelihood, not blame; and handle the crisis, the gangs, the politics, and the foreign interventions factually and from safety, never through anything that could endanger a person. Protection here is not one concern among others but the governing rule: the effective and safe path for Haiti runs through community restoration, just alternatives, the diaspora, and the international, where it is safe, and nothing — no restoration, no documentation, no appeal — is worth endangering a single person in a nation in crisis.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others — all community-based, diaspora-borne, just, and protective of everyone. Here is how they fit into a single Haitian effort.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the harm-and-restoration file. **Target identification** aims it at the just levers. **Local opposition**, understood as the community-diaspora-and-international coalition, organises the communities, the diaspora, and the partners. **Restoration, watershed, and disaster-resilience** work reforests, restores the soil, and builds resilience. **Media**, external and just, carries the restoration-and-resilience cause. The harm-and-restoration feeds all

five at once — a documented effort is a reforestation, an alternative, a watershed restoration, and a resilience effort together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, community by community and justly, they compound into real, if partial, restoration and lives saved.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the harm and the just restoration; identify the forests, the soil, the disasters, and the land; build the community-diaspora-and-international coalition and begin documentation, safely.

Middle (months–years): reforest and offer alternatives; restore the soil and watersheds; build disaster resilience; and protect the remaining forest, community by community. **Later (years):** see hillsides reforested, watersheds restored, alternatives adopted, and communities made safer — real, if partial, outcomes, as the surviving efforts show. A Haitian effort works community by community and from outside, and its fruits — a land restored, lives saved — are slow and hard-won; pace it accordingly, offer livelihood, and let the safety of everyone govern every step.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the harm and the just restoration; reforest and offer affordable alternatives that give livelihood, not bans; restore the soil and the watersheds; build disaster resilience with trees in the right places; protect the remaining forest, land, and water; use the community, the diaspora, and the international; and protect everyone involved.** The coalition that presses all five, community by community, justly, and safely, is the one that can genuinely restore the land and build resilience — the kind of result a collapsed, deforested, crisis-stricken nation allows, from outside and through the community.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing environmental ruin in Haiti is genuinely hard, and bound up with a state that has collapsed, armed groups that control much of the land, an extreme poverty that leaves families no fuel but the last trees, a reforestation history of failure, and a crisis that consumes everything, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: the deforestation is near-total, the charcoal a matter of survival, the erosion a vicious cycle, reforestation fraught, and the state collapsed. And yet the effort is far from futile, because the deforestation can be met by reforestation, agroforestry, and affordable alternatives that offer livelihood rather than bans, because the soil and watersheds can be restored, because trees in the right places save lives in every storm, because the land and water can be defended, and because the vast diaspora and the international partners and the community efforts offer real channels — and those levers of the forests, the soil, the disasters, the land, and the channels are real.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The forests are nearly gone, and the loss all but complete. The charcoal is survival, so justice forbids bans and demands alternatives.**

Community-designed restoration works, and trees in the right places save lives. But the state is collapsed, and the work is external, community-based, and slow. Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive levers of community restoration and just alternatives, and the honest weight of a ruined land and a fallen state.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the justice and safety — that give these efforts their force. Document the harm and the just restoration. Reforest and offer affordable alternatives that give livelihood, not bans. Restore the soil and the watersheds. Build disaster resilience with trees in the right places. Protect the remaining forest, land, and water. Use the community, the diaspora, and the international. And protect

everyone involved — because in a collapsed, deforested, crisis-stricken nation, an effort that restores the land and builds resilience through community restoration, just alternatives, the diaspora, and the international, offering livelihood and keeping everyone safe, is the one that is both effective and just.

Haiti is a mountainous Caribbean land, the poorest in its hemisphere, whose green hills were long ago stripped to a moonscape of bare rock and gullies, whose topsoil washes into the silted rivers with every rain, and whose people — with no fuel but the last trees and no state to help them — endure a cascade of deadly floods and landslides in every storm, amid a crisis that has broken the state itself. This guide has hidden none of that, nor pretended that the forests can be swiftly restored, or that the charcoal can justly be banned, or that the state functions, and there is no landmark victory to promise you. But the deforestation can be met, tree by tree, by a reforestation that feeds families as it holds the soil; the alternatives can spare the last forest; the watersheds can be restored; and the trees in the right places can, quite literally, save lives in the next storm. Those are the levers, and they are real: the community agroforestry that offers livelihood, not bans; the soil and watershed restoration that stops the erosion; the reforestation that buffers the disasters; and the vast diaspora, the international partners, and the community efforts that carry restoration where the state has fallen — as the reforestation projects that surge ahead even amid the crisis attest. There is no functioning state to petition, no swift restoration of a lost forest, and no work that is not shadowed by danger; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted above all on justice to the poor and the safety of everyone. But the ruined hills and the washing soil and the threatened people of Haiti are worth every careful, just, community-led effort, the levers that run through community restoration and the diaspora are real, and the patient, just, protective work of reforesting the slopes, restoring the soil, and building resilience is one that the communities, the diaspora, and the international partners can genuinely do — and, community by community, restore a ruined land and save lives in the storms to come. So can you.